

Barren mountains, turquoise lakes, and ancient monasteries touching the sky

At a Glance

Status	Union Territory of India (since 2019)
Capital	Leh
Altitude	Leh: 3,524 m | Khardung La: 5,359 m
Best Time	June – September (roads open); March for Chadar Trek
Airport	Kushok Bakula Rimpochhe Airport, Leh
Famous For	Pangong Lake, Buddhist monasteries, Nubra Valley, moto expeditions

Overview

Ladakh is India's highest inhabited plateau, a cold desert of breathtaking grandeur shaped by the mighty Himalayan and Karakoram mountain ranges. Its stark yet spectacular terrain — snow-dusted peaks, cobalt-blue lakes, dramatic gorges, ancient Buddhist monasteries perched on impossible clifftops, and colourful prayer flags snapping in the thin air — makes it one of the most otherworldly destinations on the planet.

Once a vital trading hub on the ancient Silk Route, Ladakh today is a cultural mosaic of Tibetan Buddhist, Muslim, and Dard communities. Its crystalline air, near-zero light pollution, and raw natural beauty draw an ever-growing number of trekkers, motorcyclists, photographers, astronomers and spiritual seekers. No other destination in India delivers such a powerful sense of being at the edge of the world.

Top Attractions

Pangong Tso Lake

Stretching 134 km (70% in Tibet), this mesmerising high-altitude lake at 4,350 m changes colour from turquoise to emerald to deep blue throughout the day depending on sunlight and cloud. Made globally famous by the Bollywood film '3 Idiots', it is one of India's most photographed landscapes.



■ *Pangong Tso Lake*

Hemis Monastery & Festival

The largest and wealthiest monastery in Ladakh, housing 11th-century tangkas, rare scriptures and precious artefacts. The annual Hemis Festival (June–July) features magnificent masked Cham dances celebrating Guru Padmasambhava's birthday.



■ *Hemis Monastery & Festival*

Nubra Valley & Hunder Dunes

Cross Khardung La — one of the world's highest motorable roads — to descend into this cold desert valley where double-humped Bactrian camels roam sand dunes set against a backdrop of 7,000-metre snow peaks. Diskit Monastery sits above it all.



■ *Nubra Valley & Hunder Dunes*

Zanskar Valley & Chadar Trek

One of the most remote inhabited valleys on Earth; the winter Chadar Trek (January–February) takes adventurers across the frozen surface of the Zanskar River — a once-in-a-lifetime journey through a world of ice and silence.



■ *Zanskar Valley & Chadar Trek*

Local Cuisine & Flavours

- Thukpa — hearty Tibetan-style noodle soup with vegetables or meat, the soul food of Ladakh
- Momos — steamed or fried dumplings stuffed with vegetables, paneer or yak meat
- Skyu — thick hand-rolled wheat pasta stew with root vegetables and dried meat
- Butter Tea (Po Cha) — salted yak-butter tea that warms and helps acclimatise at altitude
- Tsampa — roasted barley flour mixed with butter tea; a staple high-altitude energy food

How to Get There

- By Air: Daily flights from Delhi (1.5 hrs), Mumbai, and Srinagar to Leh airport.
- By Road — Manali–Leh Highway: Open June–October; 490 km over Rohtang & Baralacha passes.
- By Road — Srinagar–Leh Highway: Open May–October; 434 km via the scenic Kargil town.
- CRITICAL: Spend 2 full rest days in Leh on arrival to acclimatise before any activity.

Insider Travel Tips

- Carry sufficient cash — ATMs are unreliable and mobile data is patchy in remote areas.
- Obtain Inner Line Permits (available online) for Nubra Valley, Pangong Tso & Tso Moriri.
- June and September are ideal: less crowded, clear skies, accessible roads.
- Hire a local driver-guide — road conditions and seasonal closures change rapidly.
- Warm layers are essential even in July — nights at altitude drop below 5°C year-round.

*We hope this guide inspires your journey to **Ladakh**. Travel responsibly, respect local traditions, and leave only footprints.*